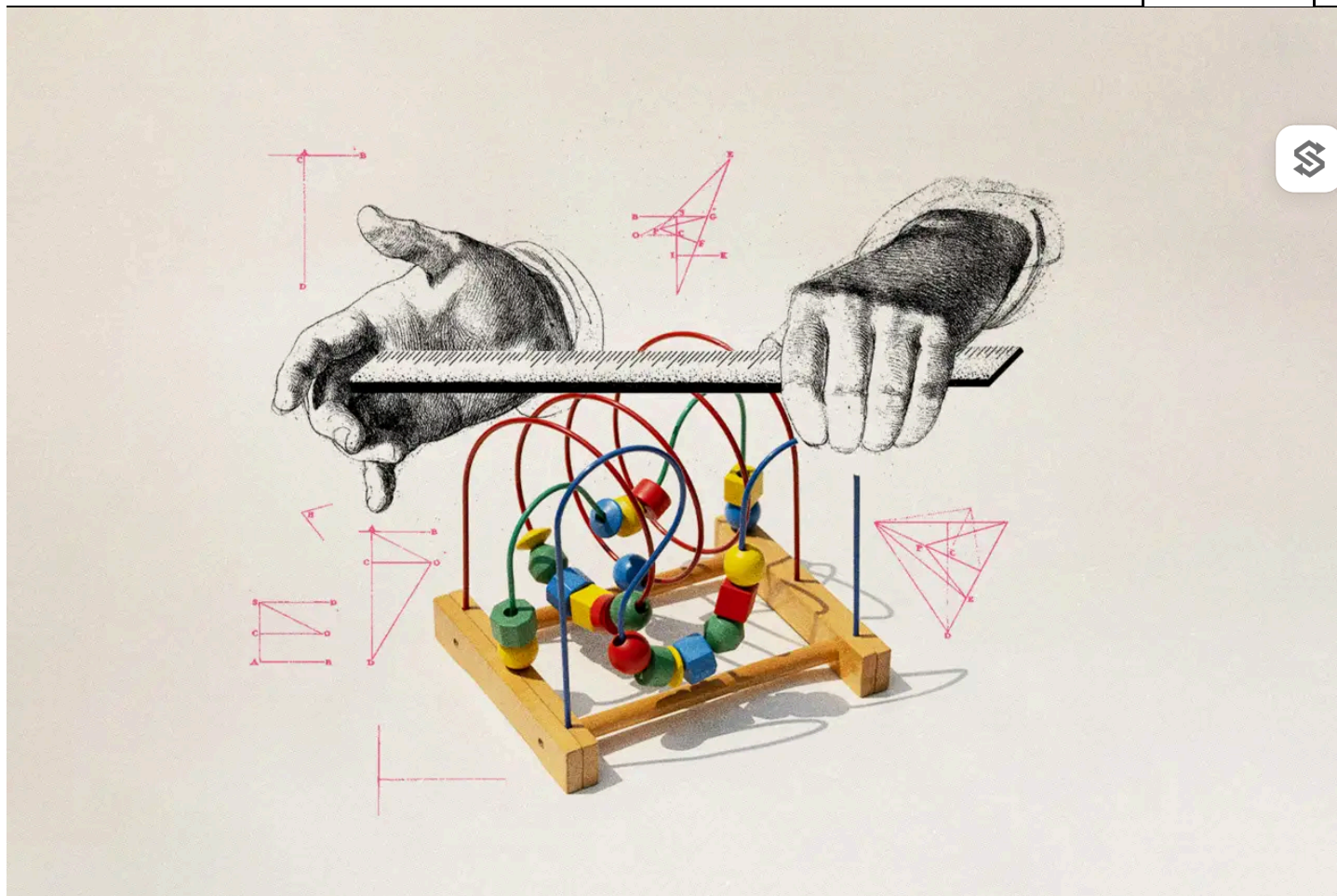




Слова , произнесенные Фиби Арсланагич-Литтл и Эллен Пастернак

Псевдонаука в детском саду

18 августа 2026 года



Translate ✓

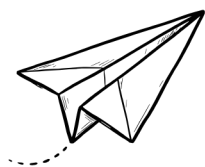
8 Минут

Если бы это оказывало явное влияние на детей, мы бы уже знали.

Вредят ли детские сады мозгу ребенка? Так считает все большее число комментаторов, особенно правых политических взглядов. Известная противница детских садов Микаэла Фуллер, дочь Джордана Питерсона, объяснила своим 1,3 миллионным подписчикам в подкасте, что детские сады влияют на детей «довольно негативно», и предостерегла их от «травмирования» своих детей. Эрика Комисар, американский психоаналитик, заявила в 2025 году в популярном подкасте «Дневник генерального директора», что детский сад повышает вероятность «развития патологических защитных механизмов» у маленьких детей в ответ на «травму» разлуки с родителями. «Это очень плохо сказывается на их мозге, — продолжила она, — и, как известно, повышает уровень агрессии».



В то же время образовательные учреждения считают, что детский сад не только необходим для развития ребенка, но и может помочь решить такие проблемы, как неравенство и насильственные преступления. Европейская комиссия утверждает, что дошкольное образование «закладывает фундамент для дальнейшего успеха в жизни». Всемирный банк заявляет, что оно может «помочь странам стать более продуктивными и успешнее конкурировать в условиях быстро меняющейся мировой экономики». Правительства по всему миру тратят миллиарды долларов на детские сады, рассматривая их как инвестиции в будущих работников.



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Кто прав? Детский сад травмирует детей или превращает их в добропорядочных граждан? А может быть, верно и то, и другое, и детский сад жертвует эмоциональным здоровьем малышей, чтобы превратить их в послушных офисных работников.

Несмотря на уверенность, с которой они делаются, доказательств в пользу таких радикальных утверждений с обеих сторон немного. Судя по всему, посещение ребенком детского сада обычно мало влияет на его дальнейшую судьбу.



Стресс-тестирование

Скептики, выступающие против детских садов, такие как Комисар, указывают на то, что у детей в детском саду повышается уровень кортизола, который в просторечии называют гормоном стресса. Это может быть правдой. У детей в детском саду уровень кортизола в слюне выше, и он повышается в течение дня. Но это нужно рассматривать в контексте. Кортизол сам по себе не является чем-то плохим: он играет важную роль в регуляции обмена веществ и циклов сна и бодрствования. Без кортизола в организме вы бы умерли. Уровень кортизола колеблется даже у тех, кто не испытывает стресса: он достигает пика при пробуждении утром, а затем снижается в течение дня, с кратковременными скачками в ответ на физические нагрузки и общение. Взаимосвязь между кортизолом и переживанием стресса изучена недостаточно. Например, уровень кортизола может быть ниже у людей, которые сообщают, что испытывают хронический стресс. Повышенный уровень кортизола в детском саду может указывать на то, что дети испытывают стресс, но он также может означать, что они возбуждены или стимулированы новизной и социальной сложностью.

Cortisol levels can change by an order of magnitude over the course of a day, which means it is easy to get completely different results for the same person from one day to the next. This, as well as variation by age and factors like how recently children have exercised or eaten, means that reliable data is hard to obtain. The studies we have may not be well powered enough to detect a genuine signal amid the noise.

We don't need salivary cortisol to know that some children find daycare stressful. Perhaps they prefer to be with their parents or find the busy

environment overstimulating. However, this is vastly different from the claim that daycare is traumatic and will permanently stunt a child's emotional development.

On the *Diary of a CEO* podcast, Komisar went even further and suggested that the stress of being separated from their parents causes the amygdala, a small part of the brain involved in emotion, of daycare-attending children to 'become active precociously'. The amygdala then supposedly 'shrivels up and burns out' because it cannot manage that stress so early', leading to chronic anxiety, depression, and ADHD. 

This is pure speculation. No one has done the research to make a claim like this. We don't even know whether people with smaller amygdalas have them in response to trauma or if they are born like that. Komisar's ideas may sound fringe, but she is a mainstream parenting commentator, with contributions to newspapers like *The Wall Street Journal* and television shows like *Good Morning America*.

Too good to be true

Anti-daycare commentators aren't the only ones making overblown claims about its effects. Many politicians and policymakers confidently state that daycare is a panacea for all manner of social ills.

In 2013, then-President Barack Obama said that every dollar spent on childcare gives a seven-dollar return, which, if true, would be extraordinarily high, higher than most transport infrastructure and comparable to the gains from providing clean water in developing countries. Obama claimed that this effect is thanks to daycare 'boosting graduation rates, reducing teen pregnancy, [and] even reducing violent crime', and that attending daycare can cause children to 'form more stable families of their own'. Hillary Clinton has said that 'the evidence is overwhelming' that spending on daycare 'is good for economic development'. Joe Biden advocated for universal preschool to give America 'the best-educated workforce' in the world. Former New York mayor Bill de Blasio said that universal preschool would create 'a more fair and just society'. Similarly, the British government has claimed that its recent expansion of subsidized daycare to nine-month-old babies will help them to 'achieve better in school' and promote their 'future success [...] on the labour market'.

If these claims were true, daycare really would be a miracle intervention. But is it? Some of the most influential data on this topic comes from moderately sized observational studies commissioned in the 1990s and 2000s in Britain and the United States. These tested children's academic and social skills at preschool age and later as they progressed into elementary school, finding that children who attended high-quality preschools performed slightly better on literacy and numeracy tests. But this early boost seems to fade by a few years into elementary school. The evidence is even more mixed on potential improvements to children's social skills, with some studies finding children who attend daycare are slightly better at cooperating, while others find they have slightly more behavioral problems.



The clearest benefit is for children from disadvantaged backgrounds, which means children living with some combination of poverty, low parental education, single parenthood, or family instability such as foster care. Two famous studies (the Perry Project and the Abecedarian Project) from the 1960s and 1970s investigated the effects of intensive, targeted interventions for black children from especially deprived families living in segregated America. Researchers reported that children in these programs later had higher earnings and lower arrest rates. (The Perry Project was cited as evidence for Obama's seven dollar claim.)

But both of these studies looked at children in very particular circumstances, who received not just ordinary daycare but intensive support that included free healthcare and home visits. Although the studies were randomized, they had small sample sizes of roughly a hundred children each, and their statistical methods were imperfect by modern standards. To suggest that universal daycare will deliver similar results in America today is, to put it generously, an audacious extrapolation.

Studies on daycare are usually observational rather than experimental. It is hard to randomize how children are looked after, which means it is hard to say whether effects are caused by childcare itself or by something else that is different about families that use it. One rare exception is a randomized controlled study from Tennessee in the 2000s, which investigated ordinary preschool education and followed children as far as high school. It reached similar conclusions to other studies on this topic: attending a standardized statewide preschool program benefited disadvantaged children, but the effects soon washed out as they entered school.

There are many potential reasons to subsidize childcare, like the fact that it means the taxpayer shoulders some of the cost of raising children. But if weakly evidenced improvements to children's future earning potential are cited as a reason, this raises questions about whether public money is being properly spent.

Throwing the baby out with the bathwater



When we raise the bar for what counts as 'good enough' parenting, people tend to have fewer children. South Korea, where it is normal for children of all ages to be very intensively and expensively tutored outside school, has the lowest fertility rate in the world at just 0.8 children per woman.

Hysteria over daycare causes needless anxiety to parents and potential parents. A couple who believe that daycare is harmful may delay parenthood until they can afford for one of them to stay at home, or feel guilty if they do have to use daycare. Others may worry that the wrong choice of preschool could lead to a lifetime of educational disadvantage.

Commentators on the left and right have their own reasons to make sweeping claims on daycare. But by framing the debate in this way, they are misrepresenting science and causing needless worry. This may even prevent some children from being born at all.

Enough studies have been conducted on daycare that if there were large, lasting impacts on children, either positive or negative, we would probably know by now. On a population level, any effects of daycare are small enough not to be obvious. Families should be encouraged to do whatever works best for them without worrying that it will damage their children.



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Ellen Pasternack is an editor at Works in Progress.



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